

Bahadur Shastri not finding a place in the list.
V.B. JAITLEY, *Dehradun*

It was a mistake to say that India has entered its 61st year of existence ("Letter from the Editor-in-Chief", April 27). India has existed since time immemorial and is one of the world's oldest civilisations. Perhaps, the letter meant to say that India is entering its 61st year of Independence from the British rule.

VEERESHWAR BHATNAGAR,
Delhi

Price Barrier-

With pre-election freebies regularly pouring in, inflation is set to scale new records, a trend which may be reversed only after general elections next year ("Price Vice", April 14). Most politicians in India generally belong to the super-rich category and can never be practically sensitive to the ill-effects of inflation borne by commoners.

SUBHASH C. AGRAWAL, *Delhi*

A decrease in food production with agricultural land being eaten up by the industrial and real estate sectors at an alarming rate can also be one of the reasons for inflation.

N. MANOHARAN, *on e-mail*

Enchanters Both

The excerpts from the latest book by Salman Rushdie showed the mark of a genius ("The Return of the Enchanter", April 14). But the magical words of your reviewer were no less in quality, depth and charm. The graceful flow of language is itself a work of art.

AMITABH THAKUR, *Lucknow*

The Gender of Smoke

Women end up smoking as it boosts their ego "Danger Signals", April 14). They start believing that they are at par with men. I wonder how such flawed individuals infuse good values in their children?

S. LAKSHMI, *on e-mail*

Corrections

Sarojini Naidu's year of birth and demise were erroneously mentioned as 1855 and 1920,

respectively in "Civil Crusader" (April 21). She was born in the year 1879 and died in 1949. The error is regretted.

In the article titled "Downsizing Manmohan" (April 28), we had referred to prime minister Manmohan Singh as a former World Bank economist. He had, in fact, served at the UNCTAD between 1966-69. The error is regretted.

-Editor

THERE'S HELL TO PAY



The Sixth Pay Commission has satisfied nobody except perhaps the IAS officers, who seem to have descended from heaven ("Burden of Sloth", April 7). It has rightly been dubbed as a report of the IAS, by the IAS, for the IAS.

R.J. KHURANA, *on e-mail*

Glossy at first sight, the pay hike for the bureaucracy is, in fact, meagre for the lowest income group and substantive for the higher-ups. However, given the day and age we live in, nobody should grudge the fact that even bureaucrats should earn more.

VANI A., *Hyderabad*

The steep hike in the pay of the Central government employees is not going to reduce corruption, or even make the bureaucracy more responsible to the people. It will only induce more arrogance.

J. N. BHARTIYA, *Hyderabad*

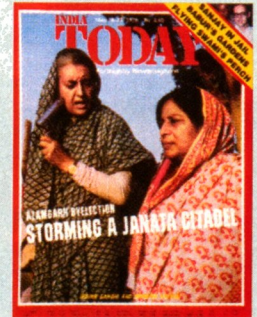
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Years Ago in India Today

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Looking for Dragons

Industry minister George Fernandes is a man in a hurry. He does not like Mrs Gandhi or the industrialists who went to her in a procession on June 26, 1975 in support of the dreaded Emergency. The procession was led by K.K. Birla, who acted as an industrial ambassador at large for the Indira regime throughout the Emergency and continues to be her man for all seasons.



The Birlas are Fernandes not only big and powerful, but are growing at a steady pace, and the former giant-killer would like to cut them to size. The snag is that he cannot do so unless the entire big business set-up in this country, which includes quite a few friends of the minister, is also cut to size. The only way he can do so is by breaking them on the grounds that they are family-held (monopoly) business houses and so much power in so few hands is bad for the country—and, by implication, its current rulers.

—Jay Dubeshi